Mayawati's relative silence in the run-up to the 2014 elections. She had started early by announcing several candidates in 2013 itself. But gradually, she began to witness the erosion of her *sarvajan* social engineering experiment that had successfully brought together Dalits, Muslims and upper castes on one platform in the 2007 assembly elections. This time, a Dalit–Muslim conflict in places like Muzaffarnagar made her position precarious. The Brahmins in any case had returned to a Modi-led BJP and the Dalit vote had splintered as well. As a result, she was left rudderless, an anomalous situation for a party with the most entrenched vote bank.

With defeat staring her in the face, by the end of the campaign it almost seemed as if Mayawati had decided to save her war chest for the UP assembly elections of 2017. Maybe, at fifty-eight, she felt she still had time on her side to fight another election.

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Time was certainly not what another prime ministerial hopeful had in 2014. At seventy-four and a cancer survivor, Sharad Pawar knew his moment had perhaps come and gone. Every interview with the Maharashtra leader included a question about his prime ministerial aspirations. Pawar's answer was equally routine. 'How can I think of becoming prime minister when I have hardly ten MPs. I am a practical man, I have no such dream.'

The truth is, Pawar has lived the prime ministerial dream for years, having first become Maharashtra chief minister at the age of just thirty-eight. He even blamed me once for preventing him from becoming prime minister. It's a story that goes back to 1991. I was a young Mumbai-based journalist in the *Times of India*. Rajiv Gandhi had just been assassinated in the midst of the general election campaign and speculation was mounting about who would succeed him as the leader of the Congress. Sitting in faraway Mumbai, we could only guess what was happening in the Delhi durbar.

Then, on a Saturday morning, a few days after Rajiv's death, we went to see Vilasrao Deshmukh, then a state minister, later to become Maharashtra